BFI POWERS INDIA'S MEDTECH FUTURE

BFI'S INTERCONNECT FELLOWSHIP SUPPORTS YOUNG MEDTECH ENTREPRENEURS; SANDEEP NAILWAL TO MENTOR STARTUPS, TACKLE LAB-TO-MARKET CHALLENGES



Dr. Geetha Manjunath (Founder, CEO & CTO, NIRAMAI Health) ; Mr. Sandeep Nailwal (Founder, BFI; Co-Founder & CEO, Polygon Foundation; Co-Founder, Sentient AI) ; Ms. Laina Emmanuel (Co-founder and CEO, BrainSightAI)

India has emerged as a global hub of medical research, frugal innovation, and low-cost engineering, yet this potential remains untapped due to a fragmented ecosystem. Young medtech entrepreneurs and their startups face many challenges including a high degree of regulatory complexity from agencies like Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO), Bureau of Indian Standards (BIS), and Indian Council of Medical Research (ICMR), limited manufacturing transition facilities, controlled clinical validation, significant funding gaps, and fragmented infrastructure that operates in silos. As a result, medtech innovations remain stuck at the proof-of-concept stage, forcing startups to either abandon development or relocate to global hubs like the US or Singapore.

Interconnect Fellowship Program

At the recent i3 Summit - Vimarsh 2025, Sandeep Nailwal, Philanthropist & Founder, Blockchain for Impact (BFI), and Co-founder & CEO of the Polygon Foundation, made a commitment to directly address these critical gaps and challenges witnessed by young entrepreneurs through BFI's Interconnect Fellowship. It may be noted that the Interconnect Fellowship is BFI's way of bridging the gaps in biomedical innovation by empowering motivated innovators to collaborate, refine and scale solutions that can create impact in Indian healthcare.

Mentorship to young entrepreneurs, startups

Under this program, Sandeep will provide handholding and mentorship to a select group of startups who were present at the Vimarsh 2025 event. He will provide the strategic guidance needed to turn scientific breakthroughs into scalable businesses, helping young entrepreneurs navigate complex regulatory pathways, secure necessary approvals from agencies like CDSCO, BIS, and ICMR, and scale production.

The program's true value lies in its ability to transform scientific breakthroughs into scalable businesses. The startups will receive tailored support in prototyping, bioassays, regulatory filing, and clinical trials, helping the medtech sector to overcome the challenges in taking an innovation from the laboratory to the market.

BFI's Interconnect Fellowship has been designed for high-potential innovators, offering a fellowship worth ₹1 lakh per month for a year to up to five fellows. This includes access to global mentors, capacity-building sessions, and networking opportunities within the BFI ecosystem. Every project will be reviewed by BFI, ensuring that only credible, high-quality proposals are showcased, and receive the necessary support for impact-driven innovation.

This holistic approach ensures that innovators are not only financially supported but also equipped with the knowledge, connections, and strategic guidance needed to succeed.

Help India become a leader in deep tech biomedical research

In order to help India become a leader in deep tech biomedical research, Sandeep has been coordinating the research, funding key programs, and fostering cross-institutional collaboration. Blockchain For Impact, recently announced the Rs 20 Cr worth National Science Prizes and has so far funded 1600 Cr to biomedical research for India. Sandeep believes that the focus must be on building indigenous capabilities across the entire healthcare stack, from deep research in clustered regularly interspaced short palindromic repeats (CRISPR) and genomics to the domestic manufacturing of diagnostic tools and medical equipment like MRI machines. At BFI, he aims to support this collective effort from the grassroots to the top research levels. The Interconnect Fellowship is a crucial next step in this vision. It will create a new pipeline of successful medtech ventures, helping to build a robust, interconnected ecosystem where innovators, funders, and policymakers can collaborate effectively. This initiative is not just about supporting a few startups; it's about helping India achieve its rightful place as a global leader in deep tech biomedical research and innovation, ensuring that groundbreaking solutions are developed within the country and benefit its people.